

Research Methodology

DeepThought Business Analytics Internship — Part A

City: Coimbatore | Segments: Precision Auto Components & Technical Textiles

1. Why I Chose Coimbatore

Coimbatore was my first choice and not a difficult one to make. I had some prior awareness that the city is known for textiles and engineering manufacturing, but I wanted to verify that before committing. A quick look at CODISSIA (Coimbatore District Small Industries Association) and a few industry articles confirmed that the city hosts a dense cluster of precision engineering and textile machinery companies — many of them promoter-driven, mid-sized, and operating in niche product categories.

What made Coimbatore specifically attractive for this research was that it is not as heavily covered as Pune or Hyderabad in B2B research circles. That meant there was likely a decent number of companies that fit the Federer profile but hadn't been picked over by too many prospecting tools already. The city also has a mix of BSE-listed mid-caps and private MSMEs, which gave me a range of company sizes to work with.

I focused on companies with actual manufacturing operations in Coimbatore — not just registered offices. For a couple of companies where the registered address was in Chennai or Mumbai, I verified through LinkedIn and their website that the factory, R&D, or founder operations were based in Coimbatore before including them.

2. Segment Selection

I picked two segments: Precision Auto Components & Engineering (Basket C) and Technical Textiles & Specialty Yarns (Basket C). Both felt like natural fits for Coimbatore given what the city is known for. I didn't try to force Coimbatore into a segment it isn't known for — picking specialty biotech or pharma intermediates here would have meant scraping for companies that aren't really concentrated in this geography.

Why Precision Auto Components:

Coimbatore has a long history of supplying precision machined parts to OEMs. Companies here have moved up the value chain over decades — from basic job-shops to AS9100-certified aerospace component manufacturers. This segment has real differentiation possibilities (aerospace-grade, defence, specialty alloys) and the right size companies.

Why Technical Textiles:

Coimbatore is one of India's largest textile manufacturing hubs, but I was careful to focus on the technical textile and specialty yarn sub-segment — not commodity spinning or weaving. The assignment rubric specifically distinguishes these. Companies making coated fabrics, PPE, functional yarns, or certified sustainable textiles are a

completely different profile from a company running 50,000 spindles of plain cotton yarn.

3. How I Found Companies

My research was mostly manual — a combination of Google searches, direct website visits, and cross-referencing with a few databases. I did not rely on any single source. My general process for each company was: find it, verify it makes something (not just trades), check if the founder or MD has a findable background, and look for at least some evidence of growth or systems.

Google Search

This was my primary starting point. I used search queries like "precision engineering companies Coimbatore", "aerospace component manufacturers Coimbatore", "specialty yarn manufacturers Coimbatore", "technical textiles Coimbatore exporters", and similar variations. I also searched for "CODISSIA member companies" and "Coimbatore BSE listed manufacturers" to get structured starting points. From each result, I opened the company website and made an initial judgment on whether it was worth investigating further.

Company Websites

Once I had a company name, the website was my main source of information. I looked at the About Us page, the Products section, any certifications or awards mentioned, and the leadership team page. Most Indian MSME websites don't have a lot of depth, but you can usually tell from a website whether a company is a genuine manufacturer or a trader dressed up as one — traders tend to have very generic product descriptions, no facility photos, no certifications, and no specific manufacturing claims.

LinkedIn

For decision-maker background checks, LinkedIn was the most useful tool. I searched for the company name and then checked the founders or MDs listed. This helped me understand their educational background, previous experience, and how long they had been running the company. For C8 (Leadership Succession), I also looked at whether there were other senior people listed at the company beyond the founder. Open roles on LinkedIn were also my primary source for C6 growth signals — I checked hiring activity for each company I included.

Screener and Tofler

For BSE-listed companies, Screener.in was useful for a quick revenue check and to see year-on-year growth. For private companies where revenue was not public, I relied on Tofler for MCA filing data where available, or kept the revenue band as "Unknown" or estimated from headcount and industry benchmarks. Revenue band accuracy was one of the harder parts of this research — private MSMEs don't publish revenue, and the MCA data is often 1-2 years delayed.

4. My Filtering Process

I looked at roughly 70-80 companies before settling on the 25 in the final list. The filtering happened in stages:

- First cut — is this a producer or a trader? A lot of companies in these segments are actually distributors or resellers that have a professional-looking website but no manufacturing. I eliminated these quickly by checking for facility photos, certifications that require manufacturing (like IATF 16949 or AS9100), and product-specific technical details on their website.
- Second cut — revenue and size. Companies that appeared to be well below Rs.30Cr or clearly above Rs.500Cr were dropped. For listed companies this was easy. For private companies I used headcount as a proxy — a company with 20 employees is unlikely to be at Rs.50Cr revenue in manufacturing.
- Third cut — ownership and structure. If a company appeared to be a subsidiary of a large group (Tata, L&T, Reliance division), or showed signs of PE ownership, I dropped it. A few companies also had very recent acquisitions which changed their promoter dynamic.
- Fourth cut — stale or inactive. Companies with no website activity in 2+ years, no LinkedIn presence, and no searchable news were removed. If I couldn't find basic information about a company online, it's also unlikely that an outreach email would reach the right person.

After these filters, I had around 35-40 candidates that I scored properly using the C3-C8 rubric. The 25 in the final list include both high-scoring A-band companies and a few B-band ones, along with one documented D-band fail (Hydro Press Industries) as required by the assignment.

5. Challenges I Ran Into

The biggest difficulty was finding reliable information on private companies. Most of the companies in this segment — especially the smaller precision engineering ones — don't have detailed online footprints. Their websites are often minimal, their LinkedIn pages are sparse, and MCA data only gives you the registered address and director names, not much else. For several companies I could confirm they were genuine manufacturers from their certifications and product depth, but couldn't pin down revenue or the exact academic background of the founder.

A second challenge was distinguishing commodity manufacturers from differentiated ones in the precision engineering space. Coimbatore has dozens of CNC machining shops and small foundries. The question was always: does this company do something that competitors can't easily replicate, or are they just one of many job-shops running the same machines? I tried to look for specific evidence — particular alloys they work with, certifications that require genuine process investment, named OEM relationships, or proprietary products.

For C7 (Systems Maturity), this was the hardest criterion to score remotely. Whether a company uses ERP or has structured costing models is not something you can easily verify from a website. I looked for indirect signals — IT or MIS roles listed on LinkedIn, references to SAP or ERP in job postings, ISO certifications that require documented quality systems, or BSE listing status (which mandates quarterly reporting and formal governance). Where I couldn't find any evidence, I scored it conservatively.

6. What I Learned About the Segment

A few things stood out during this research that I didn't expect going in:

- JV structures are common in Coimbatore engineering. Several companies here are Indian entities that have formed joint ventures with German, Swiss, or Japanese partners. These JVs often bring in European quality standards, documentation practices, and governance — which makes them interesting from a C7 and C8 standpoint even when the Indian founder credentials aren't impressive on their own.
- The defence and aerospace angle is bigger than I expected. Several precision engineering companies in Coimbatore are ISRO or defence suppliers. This is a meaningful differentiator — qualifying as an aerospace supplier requires process discipline that commodity manufacturers don't have.
- The textile segment requires careful filtering. Coimbatore has a huge number of textile companies but most of them are commodity spinners. Finding companies actually in the technical textile sub-segment — coated fabrics, certified sustainable textiles, specialty yarns for industrial use — required looking beyond the obvious "textile company Coimbatore" search and drilling into product specifics.
- BSE-listed companies are much easier to profile. For the handful of listed companies in this list, financials, director details, and growth trends were readily available. Private companies required significantly more effort for the same depth of information, and I had to accept more uncertainty in my scores for them.

7. Sources Used

- Company websites (primary source for product details, certifications, facility info)
- LinkedIn (decision-maker background, open roles, company headcount)
- Screener.in (revenue and financials for BSE-listed companies)
- Tofler / MCA filings (director details, company age, revenue for private companies where available)
- Google Search (initial discovery of company names, news articles, press releases)
- BSE filings and annual reports (for listed companies — financial data, director appointments, segment revenue)

- USFDA facility database (for any company claiming FDA-approved manufacturing)
- DSIR recognition list (for R&D recognition verification)
- Industry association directories — IVAMA (valve manufacturers), CODISSIA (Coimbatore industries) — for initial company discovery

Total time spent: approximately 7-8 hours across research, scoring, and documentation. I expect some of the revenue figures and growth estimates for private companies to need updating as more current data becomes available.